which enables them to control internal narratives and mobilise Muslim voters against the BJP-RSS on political as well as social issues. The AIMPLB, formed in 1973 as a pressure group for the precise purpose of protecting Muslim personal laws, has called the UCC "an interference in religious issues" and is contemplating legal recourse.

Uttarakhand has only a 13 per cent Muslim population, so the party feels bold enough to override their concerns. But things might heat up in Assam where the community makes up about a third of the population. The latter is already roiled over the CAA issue. Like Uttarakhand, Assam and Gujarat are also said to be exempting the tribal population from the new law. However,

THE LAW COMMISSION REPORT ON UCC IS NOT IN YET, SO THE NEW BILL IN UTTARAKHAND GIVES THE CENTRE ENOUGH TO SPARK OFF A NATIONAL DEBATE

Assam is likely to add more stringent provisions to ban child marriages.

The new laws in Uttarakhand have laid down equal inheritance rights for all children, girl or boy, and removed the distinction between legitimate, illegitimate and adopted. In addition, they allow couples, including Muslim ones, to adopt. While giving space to marriages solemnised via religious ceremonies, registration has been made compulsory. The bill outlaws polygamy, as also other practices like nikah halala and iddat, and codifies the norms for registration of marriages and divorces. The bill also has penal provisions for giving false information in registration of marriages, including jail terms, which the BJP argues is also needed to check incidents of 'love jihad'. The bill also managed to raise hackles on a purely secular terrain with its strictures on live-in relationships, inviting accusations of the party trying to 'enter the bedroom'. While stemming from old inter-community conflicts, Uttarakhand's draft UCC holds the promise of much wider debates. ■

JHARKHAND

THE LONG FIGHT BEFORE JMM



ANI



STEPPING IN Newly appointed Jharkhand CM Champai Soren with cabinet members in Ranchi, Feb. 2; inset, Hemant Soren

By Amitabh Srivastava

As Hemant Soren rose on February 5 to speak in favour of the confidence motion moved by his hand-picked successor Champai Soren in the Jharkhand assembly, the former chief minister repeatedly asserted his Adivasi origin and tore into the BJP, alleging that they were against tribals. "The BJP has been trying to swallow an Adivasi chief minister. The BJP doesn't want a tribal CM to complete five years in Jharkhand; they did not allow this even in their regimes," he said, setting the general tenor of his calm, but polemical speech. As expected, the Champai-led dispensation won the floor test after 47 Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM)-led alliance MLAs voted for the motion, against only 29 Opposition 'nay' votes. Arrested on January 31 on money-laundering charges pertaining to his alleged involvement in a land scam, Hemant is in the Enforcement